UNDERSTANDING AND SUPPORTING SOMEONE WITH ADDICTION

Understanding addiction, recognising the signs and supporting individuals and families.

What is addiction?

Addiction is a condition in which someone finds it difficult to control their use of drugs, alcohol or certain behaviours, even when these are causing harm to their health, relationships or everyday life.

Addiction is not simply a lack of willpower or a moral failing. It involves changes in the brain's reward and motivation systems, alongside psychological, social and environmental factors.

Anyone can develop an addiction, regardless of their age, background, religion or circumstances.

Why do people develop addictions?

There is rarely one simple explanation.

Some people begin using drugs or alcohol through curiosity, experimentation or social pressure. Others may use substances to cope with trauma, loneliness, anxiety, depression or difficult circumstances at home.

Over time, occasional use can develop into dependence or addiction, making it increasingly difficult to stop.

Not everyone who uses substances becomes addicted, but recognising problems early can help prevent more serious harm.

Recognising the warning signs

Common signs of addiction can include:

- Using drugs or alcohol more frequently or in larger amounts than intended.
- Repeatedly trying to stop or cut down without success.
- Becoming increasingly secretive or withdrawing from friends and family.
- Changes in mood, sleep, behaviour or relationships.
- Neglecting education, employment or family responsibilities.
- Financial difficulties or unexplained spending.
- Continuing to use substances despite harmful consequences.

These signs do not automatically mean someone has an addiction, but they may indicate that support is needed.

Addiction, loneliness and isolation

Addiction and social isolation can become a damaging cycle.

Some people turn to substances to escape loneliness, stress or emotional pain. As addiction develops, they may withdraw from friends, family, work and activities they once enjoyed.

Feelings of guilt, embarrassment and shame can make asking for help even more difficult.

Over time, isolation can deepen addiction, while addiction can increase isolation.

Breaking this cycle often begins with a conversation, understanding and reconnecting people with appropriate support.

Caring for Someone with Addiction

Behind many people struggling with addiction are mothers, fathers, brothers, sisters and other family members doing everything they can to help.

At The Salik Project UK, we have spoken to families caring for loved ones experiencing addiction, often with little support and nobody to turn to.

Caring for someone with addiction can be physically, mentally and emotionally exhausting.

The constant worry, sleepless nights, financial pressures, difficult conversations and fear of what might happen next can take a serious toll on your own health and wellbeing.

But families should understand something important: **you can play a vital role in your loved one's recovery.**

Your patience, encouragement, understanding and willingness to help someone access treatment can make a real difference. Never underestimate the importance of the support you provide.

However, you cannot carry that responsibility alone, and you are not responsible for another person's recovery.

YOU MATTER TOO.
YOUR MENTAL HEALTH MATTERS.

Taking care of yourself is not selfish. It is essential. You deserve opportunities to rest, talk about your experiences, seek support and establish healthy boundaries.

Supporting someone through addiction should never mean neglecting yourself.

Breaking the silence in South Asian communities

Within some South Asian communities, addiction remains a deeply stigmatised subject.

Concerns about family honour (*izzat*), shame (*sharam*), marriage prospects and community judgement can discourage individuals and families from seeking help.

South Asian communities have been identified as underrepresented in some specialist drug and alcohol treatment services. This raises important questions about awareness, trust, cultural understanding and barriers to accessing professional support.

We need to change this.

Addiction should not be treated as a family disgrace. Nor should people experiencing addiction be humiliated, threatened or made to feel that seeking treatment represents a failure of faith or character.

Faith, family and community can provide important sources of strength, but they should not replace appropriate medical care or professional treatment.

Recovery services are for everyone, regardless of ethnicity, religion or background.

No individual or family should feel compelled to suffer in silence.

How can you support someone experiencing addiction?

Start with a conversation. Choose a calm moment, express your concerns and listen without immediately judging or blaming.

Avoid shame and humiliation. Threats, accusations and public embarrassment can push someone further into isolation.

Encourage professional support. A GP or specialist drug and alcohol recovery service can help identify appropriate treatment.

Offer practical help. Accompanying someone to an appointment, helping them contact a service or simply listening can make a difference.

Establish healthy boundaries. Supporting someone does not mean accepting abusive behaviour, ignoring serious problems or putting yourself at risk.

Look after your own wellbeing. Families and carers may also benefit from counselling, peer support and opportunities to talk about their experiences.

Be patient but realistic. Recovery can take time and may involve setbacks. You can offer support, but you cannot force someone to change.

Is recovery possible?

Yes. People can and do recover from addiction.

Recovery may involve medical treatment, psychological therapies, rehabilitation, peer support and practical assistance with housing, employment or rebuilding relationships.

For some individuals, recovery also involves addressing underlying difficulties such as trauma, loneliness, mental health problems or social isolation.

There is no single approach that works for everyone.

Setbacks can happen, but they do not erase previous progress or mean recovery is impossible.

A person's addiction does not define their worth or their future.

Important: People who are physically dependent on alcohol or certain medicines, particularly benzodiazepines, can experience dangerous withdrawal symptoms if they stop suddenly. They should seek medical advice before stopping.

You do not have to face addiction alone

Whether you are experiencing addiction yourself, supporting a loved one or struggling with the emotional impact on your family, help is available.

The Salik Project UK works to reduce stigma, encourage open conversations and help individuals and families connect with appropriate professional services.

We do not provide clinical treatment or counselling, but we can help you explore available support and take the first step.

LOCAL SUPPORT IN ROCHDALE

TURNING POINT / ROAR
Adult drug and alcohol treatment and recovery support.

0300 555 0234

EARLY BREAK
Support for young people and families affected by substance use.
0161 723 3880

THE SALIK PROJECT UK
Community education, stigma reduction and help accessing appropriate services.
Email: contact@salikprojectuk.org
Website: www.salikprojectuk.org

Addiction does not discriminate. Neither should compassion.

Whether you are experiencing addiction or caring for someone you love, you deserve to be heard, respected and supported.

You matter. Your family matters. Your mental health matters.

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

THE SALIK PROJECT UK
To Serve. Not Judge.